Where does a $10,000 remodel actually go?

We traced one plumber's invoice from the moment it landed to April 15.

Mike, 52, plumber. 6 crew.

Day 1. The bank says available: $10,000.

Mike feels $10,000 rich. That feeling is the whole problem.

Reality: four separate claims already sit inside that one number.

Who actually owns the money

IRS, April

Crew, Friday

Parts and software

Mike

80% belongs to someone else

Day 9. The truck needs tires.

$1,100 from the same account. The one with April's money in it. Nobody noticed, because the balance still looked fine.

> "I had it on a sticky note that didn't survive a desk cleanup." **Owner, r/smallbusiness**

April 15. $2,500 is not there.

Penalty, interest, and a letter from the IRS. Not fraud. Forgetting.

The most common tax problem in small business is not understanding the rules. It is spending money that was never yours.

The fix is boring: split it the second it lands.

Four accounts instead of one balance. Tax money you cannot see as spendable. Crew money that is already Friday's. Your money, finally yours.

Profit First owners have done this by hand for a decade. The method works. The discipline is the hard part.

Mike set the rule once, in March.

25 / 40 / 15 / 20. Every payment since has split itself before he saw it. Sequence runs the rule. Mike runs the business.

What's on your sticky note right now?

Tell us in the comments. The funniest one gets remade as next week's episode.